I reached Delhi in the first week of January 2017, just ten days ahead of the Army Day, which falls on 15 January. The day symbolizes when General KM Cariappa became the first Indian Commander-in-Chief of Independent India, having taken over from General Sir FRR Bucher, on 15 January 1949. Delhi Area is responsible for the conduct of the Army Day Parade at the Cariappa Parade Ground in Delhi Cantt, as well as the Republic Day Parade on Kartavya Path (erstwhile Raj Path). Preparations and rehearsals had been going on since November and were under control, but I too needed to get into the picture. Maj Gen Rajesh Sahai, who was the COS, brought me up to speed. The schedule was for a full-scale rehearsal on the 11th, with the GOC, Delhi Area as the Reviewing Officer, followed by the Western Command Investiture Parade on the 13th, with the Army Commander as the Reviewing Officer, and finally the Army Day Parade on the 15th, with the Chief, Gen Bipin Rawat taking the salute. There was barely a week to go before my full dress rehearsal, hence the very day after reaching Delhi, I was at the parade ground. It would be Gen Rawat's first Army Day Parade as Chief and that made it all the more important that it should be flawless. The parade was conducted with military precision and the credit must go to the COS and his team who had actually done the heavy lifting. By the time I took over, the parade was already set.

The Army Day Parade though, is just a precursor to the Republic Day Parade (RDP) that follows. The RDP is conducted under the aegis of the MoD, with responsibilities assigned to each Service. However, the majority of the tasks come to the Army and down to Delhi Area. The sheer effort involved is hard to describe. From getting the Services contingents together, then getting the other CAPF contingents under our wing, followed by the NCC and other marching contingents, and finally the state tableaux

Copyright @ Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation